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From Actor to Auteur

LOVE SEX AUR DHOKHA AND *CHAURANGA* ACTOR **ANSHUMAN JHA** MAKES HIS DIRECTORIAL DEBUT WITH *LORD CURZON KI HAVELI*

WHILE TINKERING WITH THE THIRD DRAFT OF *LORD CURZON KI HAVELI* (2025), actor and producer Anshuman Jha started to think aloud about who'd be perfect for each role, the kind of lens to shoot with, and even the film's music. That's when screenwriter Bikas Ranjan Mishra suggested that Jha direct the film himself. "I took a week to decide... what tipped the scales was my conviction about the script," he says. Starring Rasika Dugal, Arjun Mathur and Paresh Pahuja, the dark thriller is a chamber drama that revolves around two unlikely South Asian couples who meet at a countryside manor in England.

It was Jha's love for the genre that triggered the film. "Alfred Hitchcock's *Rope* (1948) is one of my absolute favourite films. In 2005, I directed the German play, *Mr Kolpert*, which pays homage to *Rope* and since then I've been wanting to work in this genre. In Indian cinema, especially Hindi films, we don't see this genre a lot. The only film I can think of is *Trapped* (2016)." The 39-year-old wanted the film to explore issues of identity, migrant trauma and racism. And the title is inspired by Curzon Maidan, a historic park in Bhagalpur, Bihar, where Mishra grew up. "Through his growing up years, he often wondered about the existence of 'Curzon ground' in the middle of this town in Bihar. As the Viceroy of India, Lord Curzon's tenure in India was very controversial, especially the Partition of Bengal in 1905," says Jha. It took Mishra and Jha two years to perfect the script.

ZOOM IN After *Lord Curzon...*, Anshuman Jha has another film in the can, a sequel to 2023's *Lakadbaggha*



Jha, who made his acting debut in Dibakar Banerjee's *Love Sex Aur Dhokha* (2010), drew from what he had learnt on that set while directing his first feature. "There's a certain magic when actors are allowed to discover the nuances of their characters and the film through the process of the making of it. This is exactly what Dibakar had done for me and that's what I did on *Lord Curzon....*" The actor has been keeping busy, and has already helmed another film—a sequel to 2023's *Lakadbaggha*, about an animal-loving vigilante. "This is a big action film, with Chinese actor Sunny Pang. We've finished shooting, and it should be up for release early next year." ■

—Karishma Upadhyay